

To be credible or to be creative? Understanding the mechanisms driving user satisfaction with AI-generated content from a dual fit perspective

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ABSTRACT

Generative artificial intelligence (GAI) can fundamentally disrupt how content is produced and is increasingly integrated into organizational and individual task-performing and decision-making. This study investigates how individuals perceive and process AI-generated content by advancing the understanding of user satisfaction through an extension of dual fit theory. By theoretically grounding our investigation in dual fit theory, we propose that two key information representations (information credibility and creativity) are key drivers of user satisfaction, operating through two distinct mediating mechanisms: cognitive fit, which reflects the alignment of information with task demands, and emotional fit, which captures the match between the interaction experience and user emotions. Our model posits that both credibility and creativity distinctly influence these cognitive and emotional fit pathways. Furthermore, we examine the boundary conditions by exploring the moderating role of task representation (e.g., task routineness and task hedonism). We tested our hypotheses through two 2×2 between-subject scenario experiments with 548 and 197 participants. Across both studies, the results consistently show that information credibility positively impacts both cognitive and emotional fit. Information creativity primarily enhances emotional fit, with its effect on cognitive fit emerging under specific task conditions. Both fit dimensions, in turn, positively affect user satisfaction with the outcome and the process. Our results indicate that task routineness is a stronger moderator than task hedonism. A good match between the information and task representations (i.e., aligning credibility with routine tasks and creativity with creative tasks) leads to enhanced cognitive and emotional fit.

1. Introduction

Generative artificial intelligence (GAI) refers to artificial intelligence (AI) algorithms that generate original outputs from given prompts (Zhou et al., 2024). GAI is capable of processing trained data to generate content similar to that created by humans, and has the potential to fundamentally disrupt how information is produced (Alavi et al., 2024; Dwivedi et al., 2023). Hence, GAI will become increasingly integrated into organizational and individual task-performing and decision-making (van Dis et al., 2023). For instance, ChatGPT (Chat Generative Pre-Trained Transformer) is a generative language model released by OpenAI in late 2022. Following its release, ChatGPT saw unprecedented user adoption, becoming the fastest-growing website globally and establishing itself as the de facto market leader for publicly accessible GAI services in early 2023 (Digital Information World, 2023). Its advanced capabilities for generating diverse and coherent text across a wide range of tasks made it the most representative GAI tool (Chiarello

et al., 2024). Given its wide popularity and multi-functionality, ChatGPT serves as a prime example of a GAI service and will be the context of our investigation. In this study, we use the term “GAI service” to refer to a GAI tool like ChatGPT that users employ to enhance their task-performing process.

Since its launch, GAI has prompted widespread conversation across various fields, including the information systems (IS) discipline (Blohm et al., 2025; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Haki et al., 2025), as it is poised to challenge the core assumptions of the field, much like prior waves of AI have done (Schuetz & Venkatesh, 2020). A primary example is the belief that highly *creative* processes—such as writing, composing, and painting—are uniquely human domains, long considered impossible to automate (Rafner et al., 2023). Nonetheless, some advanced GAI systems have exhibited performance that is equivalent to or surpasses that of humans in a variety of creativity benchmarks, directly challenging this long-held belief (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2024). Such capabilities highlight GAI as a powerful new class of IT artifact. However, while GAI

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offers immense potential to drive innovation, it also presents significant challenges and ethical considerations that demand rigorous investigation (Benbya et al., 2024; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Susarla et al., 2023).

The double-edged sword effect of GAI can be understood through the tension between its remarkable **creativity** and its questionable **credibility** (Campbell et al., 2022). On the one hand, what makes GAI unique compared to other AI tools is its capacity to use massive amounts of human-generated data to creatively generate content, transforming tasks once thought to be performed only by humans into predictive problems that algorithms can address (De Vries, 2020; Rafner et al., 2023). On the other hand, this **creativity** is accompanied by significant drawbacks. Among these, the phenomenon of GAI hallucinations is particularly prominent (Onder & McCabe, 2025), referring to instances where GAI systems produce outputs that are factually incorrect, nonsensical, or entirely fabricated—often with a high degree of confidence that makes them appear plausible (Onder & McCabe, 2025). Coupled with concerns about misinformation and bias propagation (Paul et al., 2023), these issues pose a substantial threat to the perceived **credibility** of AI-generated information (Lund et al., 2023; Orduña-Malea & Cabezas-Clavijo, 2023).

To navigate this complex landscape and ensure the responsible development of GAI, a human-centered AI (HCAI) approach becomes essential (Capel & Brereton, 2023; Shneiderman, 2020). HCAI shifts the focus from purely technological advancement to ensuring that AI systems align with human needs and values (Stahl & Eke, 2024). The tension between GAI's creativity and credibility can be precisely understood within a structured HCAI framework, which delineates between an AI system's purposes, its underlying values, and its functional properties (Schmager et al., 2025). Specifically, GAI's capacity for creativity directly serves the HCAI purpose of augmentation—enhancing human performance and capabilities (Schmager et al., 2025). Simultaneously, the credibility of its output is a direct manifestation of foundational HCAI values, such as human protection from misinformation, and essential system properties, including reliability and trustworthiness (Schmager et al., 2025). Given that HCAI focuses on human experiences, fulfillment, and needs, with the aim of amplifying, augmenting, and enhancing human performance, user **satisfaction** emerges as a critical, human-centric metric. Previous studies have emphasized the significance of maintaining user satisfaction with AI-enabled services (Djelassi et al., 2018; J. Zhang et al., 2024; Q. Zhang et al., 2024), as it plays a critical role in influencing continued usage (Bhattacharjee & Lin, 2015). Hence, scholars and practitioners should direct greater attention towards refining the design of GAI services with the aim of augmenting user satisfaction. From a user-centric viewpoint, creativity and credibility are fundamental components of the perceived informational value of GAI services (Setyani et al., 2019). Grounded in this HCAI perspective, this study therefore aims to understand how users' satisfaction with GAI-generated content is formed through the lens of information value. Despite the importance of this issue, several research gaps remain.

First, while existing research acknowledges GAI's creative capabilities and separately addresses the effects of credibility on user responses (e.g., Kim et al., 2023; Zhao et al., 2025), to our knowledge, no study has integrated both creativity and credibility to explore the underlying mechanisms through which these information value dimensions influence user satisfaction. Additionally, prior studies have emphasized the importance of distinguishing between satisfaction with outcome (SO) and satisfaction with process (SP) when assessing user satisfaction with technology, as users may find the output valuable yet remain dissatisfied with the interaction experience itself (Ivanov & Cyr, 2014; Zhang, 2013). For instance, a user may appreciate the quality of the generated text (outcome) but may find the interface confusing or the response time slow (process). However, existing GAI studies often treat satisfaction as an overall construct, failing to capture the multifaceted nature of the user experience, a central principle of HCAI. Consequently, we propose our first research question:

RQ1. How do information credibility and creativity impact SO and SP?

To address this research question, our study develops a theoretical model grounded in an extension of cognitive fit theory (CFT). CFT provides a robust initial framework by positing that a strong alignment between the way information is presented (information representation) and the user's task requirements creates a state of cognitive fit, leading to more effective mental processing (Vessey, 1991). A core principle of CFT is the assumption that when cognitive fit is high, users can process information more efficiently and with less cognitive effort, which in turn enhances their performance and satisfaction (Giboney et al., 2015; Shiau & Huang, 2023).

However, GAI services, unlike the IT artifacts examined in structured decision-making contexts (Giboney et al., 2015), are characterized by their increasingly human-like interaction styles, inherent adaptability, and the generation of creative content (Chen et al., 2025; Gyeong Kim & Chang Lee, 2025; Lee & Chung, 2024). These unique characteristics shift user expectations beyond purely functional outcomes towards experiential value, thereby eliciting both cognitive and affective responses from users (Chen et al., 2025). Consequently, CFT alone, with its primary focus on cognitive processing, cannot fully explain satisfaction in these novel interactive contexts, as it largely overlooks the crucial affective dimensions of user-system interaction. In human-GAI interaction, users not only expend cognitive resources to evaluate the utility of the AI-generated content, but also experience a range of rich emotions towards this innovative technology (Montag & Elhai, 2025; Shiau & Huang, 2023; Wendel & Dellaert, 2009). To capture this crucial affective dimension, we therefore extend CFT by introducing the concept of emotional fit. We define emotional fit as the alignment between the emotional responses evoked by the AI-generated content and the user's desired or expected emotional state for a given task (Chen & Zhou, 2025; Shiau & Huang, 2023). This dual-pathway perspective, which integrates both cognitive and emotional mechanisms, allows us to construct a more comprehensive model. Specifically, it leads us to propose that the core information representations of GAI content (information credibility and creativity) distinctly influence these cognitive and emotional fit pathways, which, in turn, serve as the key mechanisms driving SO and SP.

Furthermore, GAI services are essentially information services that output content based on given prompts (Yamson, 2023). Previous research has indicated that the evaluation process of services may vary depending on task types (Xiao & Kumar, 2021). Generally, in terms of the objectives of users using GAI services, tasks can be characterized into **hedonic** and **utilitarian** types (Wang et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2024), while from the routineness of tasks performed by GAI, tasks can be characterized into **routine** and **creative** types (Przegalinska et al., 2025; Teng & Song, 2011; Wang et al., 2014). Investigating user satisfaction with services without distinguishing task types may result in unexplained differences in potential value (Yang et al., 2024). Given the algorithm resources invested in GAI, generating content indiscriminately regardless of task types might cause unnecessary waste. Therefore, it is significant to highlight the evaluation differences of users towards GAI services under different task types. However, previous research has not provided empirical evidence on whether users' cognitive and emotional evaluation processes vary across different task types. Thus, we propose the second research question:

RQ2. Does the effect of information representations on perceived cognitive fit and emotional fit differ across various task types?

To address this question, we examine the moderating roles of both task routineness (routine vs. creative) and hedonism (hedonic vs. utilitarian). We thus make three main contributions to the literature. First, this study advances the literature on GAI user satisfaction. Specifically, we identify the two dimensions of the value of AI-generated information (i.e., information credibility and creativity) as key antecedents of user satisfaction. Additionally, we explore cognitive and emotional fit as potential mechanisms underlying satisfaction formation and distinguish

between SO and SP. Second, we propose the dual fit theory that includes cognitive and emotional dimensions of fit and contribute to CFT by extending the information representation of this theory to the information values (i.e., information credibility and creativity) in the context of GAI. Third, this research broadens the knowledge base on service segmentation and GAI research by examining how information creativity and credibility interact with task routineness and hedonism in influencing users' responses to AI-generated content.

2. Literature review

2.1. The value of AI-generated information and GAI satisfaction

This study focuses on the perceived information value of AI-generated content. Consistent with the view of information as an experience good (Rusho & Raban, 2020), whose qualities are often fully revealed only upon interaction, we conceptualize information value as users' evaluations of the worth or usefulness of the experienced AI-generated content (Pee et al., 2020). Crucially, understanding how users value AI-generated outputs requires acknowledging the characteristic of information itself. Specifically, evaluating information a priori is inherently challenging. Users typically must first engage with or "experience" the information—by reading, viewing, or interacting with it—to properly assess its value to them (Rusho & Raban, 2021). Dimensions central to our study, such as the information credibility and creativity of AI-generated content, are precisely the kinds of qualities that necessitate such post-interaction evaluation (Kim et al., 2023; Lee & Chung, 2024). Therefore, aligning with this understanding, the perceived credibility and creativity measured in our study reflect users' value judgments formed after they engage with the AI-generated content stimuli (Rusho & Raban, 2020). This post-experience evaluation is fundamental to understanding user perceptions of GAI outputs (Shin et al., 2024).

Understanding how users arrive at these post-experience information value judgments involves considering their information processing routes. A key theory is the dual-process theory, which posits that users engage in both central and peripheral routes when processing information (Zhou et al., 2017). The central route depends on individual cognitive resources, typically involving deliberate reasoning based on the information itself. In contrast, the peripheral route relies more on simple cues or superficial features (Zhang et al., 2014). In this study, we focus on the central route related to the characteristics of the information itself to operationalize information creativity and credibility as two dimensions of information value for two primary reasons. First, we focus on users' subjective evaluations of AI-generated content itself, which rely on users' cognitive efforts. Second, the value of information involves the extent to which information satisfies user needs and the assessments users make about information quality (Zhang et al., 2014; Zhou et al., 2017). Our literature review on the value of AI-generated content and GAI satisfaction (see Appendix A) reveals that prior studies have overlooked an important aspect of information value: information creativity, which represents the disruptive factor that distinguishes GAI from other AI technologies and is a key source for satisfying user information needs (Benbya et al., 2024; Rafner et al., 2023).

Furthermore, AI-generated information's value is key in bridging information providers and users, which is crucial for influencing user satisfaction and behavioral intentions (Rusho & Raban, 2021; Zhou et al., 2017). For instance, the IS success model offers a theoretical framework, identifying variables related to information value (e.g., information quality) as a principal determinant of satisfaction (Petter et al., 2013). This relationship aligns with the broader cognitive-affective-behavior paradigm, which suggests users first form cognitive judgments (e.g., evaluating information credibility/value) that subsequently influence their satisfaction (J. Zhang et al., 2024; Q. Zhang et al., 2024). Conceptually, this study aligns with a significant stream of IS research that defines satisfaction as a purely affective

state—an emotional response to a technology interaction, as opposed to a cognitive judgment (Briggs et al., 2008). Treating satisfaction as an affective response allows it to be modeled as a distinct outcome that follows from cognitive appraisals (e.g., cognitive fit), thus ensuring conceptual clarity in the causal chain (Wang, 2008). In the field of IS, satisfaction is one of the most widely examined constructs for assessing the success of IT artifacts (Cheng et al., 2020). However, satisfaction is not a monolithic concept. Prior research has emphasized the necessity of distinguishing between affective responses related to the interaction process and those related to the achieved outcome (Briggs et al., 2008, 2013; Zhang, 2013). Zhang's (2013) affective response model, for example, provides a theoretical framework by differentiating between process-based and outcome-based affective evaluations, arguing that users develop different feelings about the journey of using a technology versus the result obtained. This distinction between SP—affective contentment derived from the way of using the technology—and SO—affective contentment with the result achieved—is particularly important in the context of highly interactive technologies (i.e., GAI in this study) (Djelassi et al., 2018; Folse et al., 2025; Zhu et al., 2019). In human-GAI interaction, users do not just receive information; they actively co-create it through prompts (Yamson, 2023). Consequently, their overall satisfaction is tied to both the generated content (the outcome) and the experience of interacting with the GAI (the process). Studies on other interactive systems, such as self-service technologies, data analysis tools, and web-based collaboration tools, indicate that users distinctly evaluate process and outcome, and both dimensions contribute to overall assessments and continued use intentions (Djelassi et al., 2018; Ivanov & Cyr, 2014; Zhu et al., 2019).

Despite its theoretical grounding (Zhang, 2013) and practical relevance (Djelassi et al., 2018; Folse et al., 2025; Zhu et al., 2019), the SO/SP distinction has been largely overlooked in the GAI literature, which often treats satisfaction as an overall construct (see Appendix A). This distinction is important because users may be satisfied with the task-performing outcome but dissatisfied with the process (Ivanov & Cyr, 2014). Therefore, this study distinguishes between SO and SP to capture the overall user experience in the context of GAI. Specifically, SO refers to the affective contentment experienced with the GAI's output and the information obtained, while SP refers to the affective contentment derived from the journey and method of using the GAI to accomplish the task (Briggs et al., 2008; Cheng et al., 2020; Ivanov & Cyr, 2014). Moreover, these studies on GAI satisfaction do not deconstruct the mechanisms and boundary conditions by which users perceive and process AI-generated content to form satisfaction. Considering that dual fit theory is suitable for understanding this mechanism, this study tries to reveal the central role of fit in fostering user satisfaction.

2.2. Dual fit theory

Research in the IS field has demonstrated that user satisfaction can be explained through fit theory (Shiau & Huang, 2023; Sun et al., 2016). CFT, which originates from decision-making research, has been widely applied to examine how information representation influences user task performance across diverse contexts, such as chatbots (Chen et al., 2021), knowledge-based systems (Giboney et al., 2015), and online and offline shopping (Garaus et al., 2015; Hong et al., 2004). CFT establishes a theoretical framework for understanding how information and task representation impact user satisfaction via cognitive fit (Vessey, 1991). Specifically, information representation refers to the way the information is presented as an aid to solving that task, and task representation refers to the task that the user is expected to complete (Chen et al., 2021). The alignment between these two forms a mental representation, which, within the traditional CFT framework, describes the cognitive processes users engage in to solve problems. These processes play a crucial role in mediating the consequences of cognitive fit, such as satisfaction (Chen et al., 2021; Shiau & Huang, 2023). In the context of GAI, we conceptualize information representation as the information

credibility and creativity, which are the significant information values that satisfy user information needs. Moreover, two generic task representations are characterized by aspects of task routineness and hedonism.

While the principle of achieving a good match remains central, the characteristics of human-GAI interaction suggests that the resulting mental representation is not purely cognitive. Existing literature on fit theory has primarily focused on technologies that are mechanical and analytical, with users seldom forming emotional connections with these technologies (Huang & Rust, 2018; Shiau & Huang, 2023). However, with technological advancements, users are increasingly engaging in more interactive and personalized relationships with IT artifacts, especially with anthropomorphic AI technologies, emphasizing the growing importance of emotional connections between humans and machines (Blut et al., 2021; Chen et al., 2025; Uysal et al., 2022). Taking GAI as an example, users can not only reduce cognitive efforts in task completion (productivity-oriented) but can also easily establish emotional connections with it under the influence of anthropomorphic cues (pleasure-oriented) (J.S.Kim et al., 2024; T. Kim et al., 2024; Saviano et al., 2025). For instance, users may employ GAI services for hedonistic purposes, such as using ChatGPT to tell jokes and engage in games when they are experiencing boredom (Chiarello et al., 2024). These affective use cases demonstrate that user interaction with GAI is not purely cognitive or utilitarian, highlighting the limitations of traditional fit theory in explaining such usage behavior. Yet, existing studies have rarely simultaneously addressed the impacts of cognitive and emotional fit on new technologies. Therefore, building on CFT and in line with recent calls in the literature (e.g., Shiau & Huang, 2023), we propose a **dual fit theory** that extends the concept of mental representation to include both cognitive and emotional dimensions. Cognitive fit captures the alignment between the AI-generated information representation and the cognitive demands in the user's task (Chen et al., 2021; Garaus et al., 2015; Vessey, 1991). In contrast, emotional fit focuses on the affective dimension, defined as the alignment between the emotional responses elicited by the human-GAI interaction experience and the user's expected or desired emotional state (Chen & Zhou, 2025; Shiau & Huang, 2023). This distinction is crucial: cognitive fit assesses the information-task match from a cognitive standpoint, while emotional fit assesses the experience-user match from an affective standpoint. Cognitive and emotional fit occur when information representation aligns well with task representation, resulting in greater satisfaction and more effective task performance (Giboney et al., 2015; Shiau & Huang, 2023).

2.3. Task representation

In this study, we focus on investigating the effects of two generic task representations, namely task routineness and task hedonism, building upon previous research that distinguished between various task types. In IS literature, the most in-depth exploration of task representations revolves around the research on task-technology fit (Haegemans et al., 2019; Howard & Rose, 2019; Wang et al., 2014). These studies suggest that task routineness significantly influences key aspects of users' information processing (Ruan et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2014). Additionally, in service and marketing research, task hedonism has been identified as another critical factor affecting users' evaluation of IT-based services (Wang et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2024).

From the perspective of task routineness, tasks are characterized into two types: routine and creative. Routine tasks are generally characterized by structure, convergent thinking, additive processing, and information recall to reach defined solutions, for example, searching for structured information. In contrast, creative tasks typically involve less structure, divergent thinking, cyclic processing, and novel information combination to generate new possibilities (John & Kundisch, 2015), for instance, writing a new report or composing a short story. Prior studies on fit have primarily examined how individuals form mental

representations (i.e., cognitive and emotional fit) of the task based on their perceptions in various routine tasks, such as the searching and browsing tasks in e-commerce platforms (Chen, 2017; Chen et al., 2021; Hong et al., 2004) and shop environment tasks (Garaus et al., 2015). However, these studies have primarily addressed only routine tasks. In the contemporary business environment, creative tasks hold significant importance, as creativity is a key driver of individual and organizational competitiveness (Benbya et al., 2024; John & Kundisch, 2015; Rafner et al., 2023). Moreover, GAI is gaining interest among scholars and practitioners because large language models possess massive parameters that enable GAI to leverage deep learning techniques for generating creative content (Dwivedi et al., 2023; Peres et al., 2023). Therefore, extending the boundaries of CFT from a single routine task scenario to a holistic perspective has important theoretical and practical implications (John & Kundisch, 2015).

Furthermore, prior research has widely recognized the dichotomy in individuals' use of IT-based services towards achieving hedonic and utilitarian objectives (Tafesse, 2021; Wang et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2024). Specifically, users with a utilitarian focus strive for task efficacy, prioritizing performance and productivity outcomes (Tafesse, 2021), whereas those inclined towards hedonic focus seek enjoyment and emotional experience (Garaus et al., 2015). This contrast between hedonic and utilitarian orientations in IT-based service scenarios has been examined in various contexts, such as mobile apps (Tafesse, 2021), virtual advisors (Li & Mao, 2015), service robots (Yang et al., 2024), and AI assistants (Yuan et al., 2022). However, the potential boundary conditions of task hedonism in the context of GAI remain poorly understood (Paul et al., 2023). With these gaps in mind, this study investigates the moderating effects of task routineness and hedonism in the context of GAI.

The main constructs and their contextual examples of this study are summarized in Table 1.

3. Research model and hypotheses

For the purposes of this study, drawing on the dual fit theory, we examine how information credibility and creativity affect cognitive and emotional fit, which in turn impacts SO and SP. We further use multiple group analysis across different task routineness (routine vs. creative) and hedonism (hedonic vs. utilitarian). Fig. 1 summarizes the research model.

3.1. Information credibility and fit

Information credibility, in the context of GAI, denotes the extent to which users perceive the GAI's output as believable and trustworthy (Xiao & Benbasat, 2007; Zhao et al., 2025). According to uncertainty reduction theory, when users perceive AI-generated information as credible, their perceived uncertainty regarding the information's accuracy, reliability, and relevance for their task diminishes significantly (Srivastava & Chandra, 2018). This trust reduces the cognitive burden users experience during information processing (Son et al., 2020) and leads to a stronger perception of alignment between the AI-generated content and the cognitive demands of the task—hence, fostering a higher degree of cognitive fit. For example, when users employ ChatGPT for information search, if the answers provided by ChatGPT are deemed credible due to authoritative sources and well-reasoned arguments, users are more likely to perceive a high level of fit between the information and their search task, thus increasing cognitive fit.

Beyond its cognitive impact, information credibility also shapes the affective dimension of user-GAI interaction, leading to enhanced emotional fit. This relationship is underpinned by research on trust and emotion in human-AI interaction (Lacity et al., 2024; Saffarizadeh et al., 2024). When users perceive AI-generated content as credible, they are more inclined to develop positive emotions towards the GAI, such as trust, security, and pleasure, reducing anxiety arising from concerns

Table 1
Key constructs and contextual examples of the current study.

Constructs	Definitions	Contextual examples	Reference
Information Credibility	The extent to which AI-generated content is perceived as believable and trustworthy.	Medical Symptom Check: A user consults GAI services to check potential symptoms. High credibility would mean the AI provides information aligned with established medical guidelines and avoids alarmist or unsubstantiated claims.	(Xiao & Benbasat, 2007; Zhao et al., 2025).
Information Creativity	The extent to which AI-generated content is perceived as novel, original, and imaginative.	Creative Writing: A user asks GAI services to write a short story for entertainment. High creativity would be demonstrated by a plot that is original, with unexpected twists and turns, and characters that are vividly imagined.	(Boussiou et al., 2024; Casaló et al., 2021; Lee & Chung, 2024)
Cognitive fit	The perceived alignment between the AI-generated content's representation and the cognitive demands of the user's task.	Product Feature Comparison: A consumer uses GAI services to compare features of different smartphones. High cognitive fit is achieved when the GAI presents a side-by-side comparison table highlighting key specifications and differences across models.	(Chen et al., 2021; Garaus et al., 2015; Vessey, 1991).
Emotional fit	The perceived alignment between the emotional responses elicited by the human-GAI interaction experience and the user's expected emotional state.	User Seeking Entertainment: A user turns to GAI services for entertainment and lighthearted interaction. High emotional fit is achieved when the GAI responds with witty humor, playful language, and engaging storytelling.	(Chen & Zhou, 2025; Shiau & Huang, 2023).
Satisfaction with outcome (SO)	The affective contentment experienced specifically with the GAI's output and the information obtained.	Report Generation: A user requests GAI services to generate a market research report. High SO is reflected when the user is pleased with the report's comprehensiveness, accuracy, and actionable insights it provides.	(Briggs et al., 2008; Cheng et al., 2020; Ivanov & Cyr, 2014)
Satisfaction with process (SP)	The affective contentment derived from the journey and method of using the GAI to accomplish the task.	Helpful Prompting Experience: A user works with an AI writing assistant. High SP is evident when the user feels satisfied with the GAI's helpful prompts, suggestions, and iterative refinement process, which makes the writing task feel collaborative and productive.	(Briggs et al., 2008; Cheng et al., 2020; Ivanov & Cyr, 2014)

about the GAI's potential risks (Gao et al., 2024; Zhao et al., 2025). This positive emotional tone aligns with the user's expected positive emotional state when using reliable technology, thereby enhancing emotional fit (Chen & Zhou, 2025). For example, in GAI-assisted report writing, if users perceive the information provided by the GAI as credible, they are likely to feel more confident and relaxed during the usage process. These positive emotional experiences contribute to enhancing users' emotional fit. We thus hypothesize:

H1. a-b. Information credibility is positively associated with cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b).

3.2. Information creativity and fit

Information creativity, in the context of AI-generated content, is defined as the extent to which users perceive the GAI's output as novel, original, and imaginative (Casaló et al., 2021). In GAI-assisted tasks, creative outputs can enhance cognitive fit by improving the quality of the user's mental problem-solving process (Giboney et al., 2015). According to CFT, when information is presented in a novel manner, users are prompted to process it more deeply, leading to a more flexible mental representation of the task (Boussiou et al., 2024). This enhanced engagement facilitates a stronger perceived alignment between the AI-generated information and the user's cognitive model of the task, which is the essence of cognitive fit (Garaus et al., 2015). For instance, even in a routine task like product comparison, a creative presentation of information (e.g., using an insightful analogy) can make complex details more understandable, thereby reducing cognitive load and improving fit. In a creative task, this effect is more direct, as novel information provides the raw material for generating original solutions (Lee & Chung, 2024). Thus, information creativity strengthens the link between the GAI's output and the user's cognitive demands.

Beyond its impact on cognitive processing, information creativity also plays a pivotal role in shaping users' affective responses to the GAI interaction, driving emotional fit. According to expectancy violation theory, deviations from pre-existing expectations, particularly positive and unexpected deviations, can elicit strong emotional responses (Han et al., 2022). In the context of human-GAI interaction, where users may initially hold functional expectations, encountering imaginative GAI outputs can be a delightful surprise that surpasses these baseline expectations (Graham & Stough, 2025). This positive experience aligns the user's elicited emotional state with a desirable one, thereby directly enhancing emotional fit. For example, when utilizing an AI image generator, if the AI generates images that are unexpectedly imaginative and visually captivating, users are likely to experience delight, significantly enhancing their emotional connection with the GAI interaction, thereby fostering higher emotional fit (Chen & Zhou, 2025; Shiau & Huang, 2023). Therefore, we propose:

H2. a-b. Information creativity is positively associated with cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b).

3.3. The moderating effects of task representation

CFT posits that the effectiveness of an IT tool results from the interaction between information representation and task representation (Giboney et al., 2015). A strong fit enhances problem-solving efficiency by aligning with the user's limited cognitive resources (Huang et al., 2013). According to our dual fit model, both cognitive and emotional fit stem from this alignment. Cognitive fit reflects a match with the task's cognitive demands, while emotional fit reflects a match with the user's affective expectations. Thus, when information representation is appropriate for the task context, it should enhance both cognitive processing and the user's emotional connection to the experience (Shiau & Huang, 2023).

To clarify how task representation moderates the effect of information representation, we propose a theoretical hierarchy where task

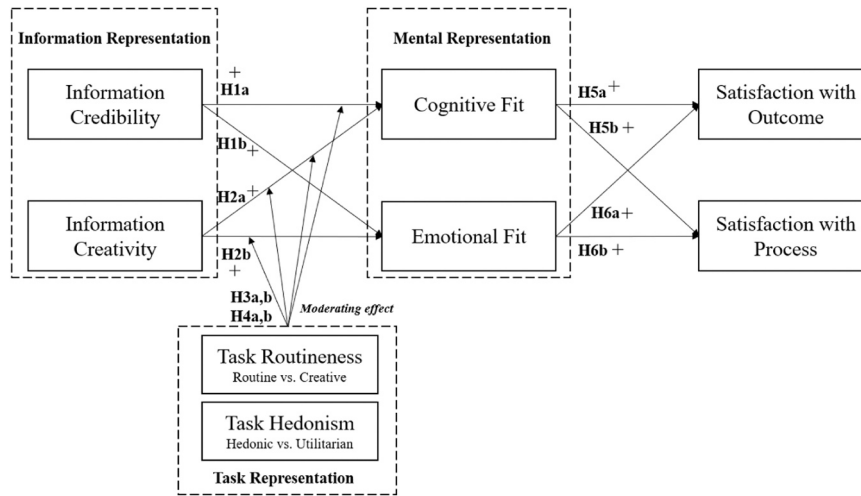


Fig. 1. Research model.

routineness serves as the primary moderator and task hedonism as a secondary one. We argue that task routineness (routine vs. creative) is the primary moderator because it directly defines the fundamental cognitive processing structure of the task, which is the core focus of CFT (Garaus et al., 2015; Hong et al., 2004). Task routineness significantly impacts cognitive processes by determining the structure and predictability of tasks, thereby shaping the cognitive strategies users employ when interacting with GAI (Chung & Jackson, 2013). Specifically, routine tasks are structured, analyzable, and require convergent thinking to arrive at correct solutions (Wang et al., 2014). Creative tasks are, by contrast, unstructured, open-ended, and require divergent thinking to explore novel possibilities (John & Kundisch, 2015). This distinction, rooted in the core principles of CFT, establishes task routineness as the primary moderator: information attributes that are accurate (i.e., credibility) will be most valuable in routine tasks (Benbya et al., 2024), while those that are novel (i.e., creativity) will be most valued in creative tasks (Setyani et al., 2019).

Task hedonism (utilitarian vs. hedonic), on the other hand, defines the user's motivation or overarching goal for performing the task (Wang et al., 2023). While this motive influences how users approach a task, we posit that it does not fundamentally change the core cognitive processes required by the task's structure itself. Within the CFT framework, the cognitive processing involved in handling AI-generated information is largely determined by the task's intrinsic characteristics (i.e., its routineness), rather than solely by the user's underlying objectives (Bačić & Henry, 2022; Chen et al., 2021; Djurica et al., 2023; Garaus et al., 2015). Therefore, while task hedonism is expected to play a role, its impact on the fundamental cognitive and emotional fit derived from the alignment between information representation and task structure is hypothesized to be secondary to that of task routineness. Drawing from the elaboration likelihood model, we posit that utilitarian tasks, being goal-driven and functional, induce a higher motivation for central elaboration of task-relevant information cues (Gao et al., 2021). Hedonic tasks, being focused on affect and enjoyment, may lead to processing that gives more weight to peripheral cues (Gao et al., 2021). Therefore, within a given task structure (e.g., within routine tasks), the utilitarian motive will amplify the need for the functionally relevant information cue compared to the hedonic motive (Wang et al., 2023).

This two-level moderation allows us to hypothesize a descending order for the effects of credibility and creativity. Accordingly, we reference the typology outlined in Fig. 2. Based on this matrix, we can now develop our hypotheses for the four task conditions derived from our 2×2 design: routine-utilitarian (RU), routine-hedonic (RH), creative-utilitarian (CU), and creative-hedonic (CH). This matrix highlights the interplay between task routineness and hedonism and

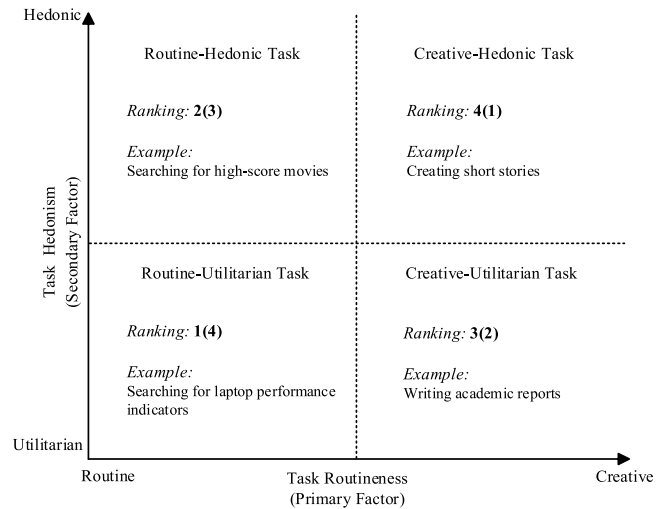


Fig. 2. A typology of task representations that GAI can perform. Note. The ranking numbers outside and inside the parentheses refer to the degree of impact of task representation on the users' credibility and creativity evaluations during task processing, respectively.

illustrates the order in which the four types of tasks affect the credibility evaluation by users during the task processing (the number outside the parentheses). Conversely, for the creativity evaluation, this order is reversed (the number inside the parentheses).

The value of information credibility is maximized when the cognitive demand for accuracy and reliability is highest. First, our theoretical hierarchy predicts that its influence on both cognitive and emotional fit will be stronger in routine tasks (RU, RH) than in creative tasks (CU, CH). In line with CFT, routine tasks require structured processing where factual correctness is crucial for reducing uncertainty and cognitive load (Srivastava & Chandra, 2018). Credible information directly serves this primary cognitive demand. In contrast, creative tasks prioritize novelty and exploration, which diminishes the relative importance of credibility for achieving fit (Benoit & Miller, 2019).

Furthermore, within routine tasks (i.e., RU and RH) and creative tasks (i.e., CU and CH), we posit that a utilitarian motive will amplify the importance of credibility more than a hedonic motive. When comparing the two routine tasks, we expect the impact of credibility to be higher in the RU tasks condition than in the RH condition. RU tasks, such as finding laptop specifications for work, involve functional stakes and prompt high elaboration on objective facts, making credibility essential

(Camilleri, 2024). RH tasks, like finding movie ratings, are also structured, but the specific goal is subjective enjoyment. While users still value credible information, the lower cost of error slightly reduces the primacy of credibility compared to an instrumental task (Das et al., 2019). A similar logic applies within the two creative tasks, where credibility's influence, though already diminished, should be stronger in the CU condition than in the CH condition. CU tasks, such as composing an academic report, require novel synthesis that must still be grounded in credible information to be useful (Son et al., 2020). Conversely, CH tasks, like writing a fictional story, are acts of imagination where factual credibility is largely irrelevant to achieving fit. This step-by-step logic leads to a descending order of effect strength. We thus propose:

H3. a-b: For different tasks, the impact of information credibility on cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b) follows a descending order: routine-utilitarian task > routine-hedonic task > creative-utilitarian task > creative-hedonic task.

Conversely, the value of information creativity is maximized when the cognitive demand for novelty and divergent thinking is highest. Our framework thus predicts its influence will follow a descending order that is largely the reverse of credibility's. Specifically, the effect of creativity will be stronger in creative tasks (CU, CH) than in routine tasks (RU, RH). By definition, creative tasks require novel inputs to facilitate divergent thinking and generate original outputs (Lee & Chung, 2024); creative information directly aligns with this core cognitive demand. In routine tasks, which require convergent thinking, such information may be perceived as irrelevant cues, thus having a minimal effect on fit (John & Kundisch, 2015).

Within routine tasks (i.e., RU and RH) and creative tasks (i.e., CU and CH), we expect the hedonic motive to amplify the importance of creativity more than the utilitarian motive. When comparing the two creative tasks, the impact of creativity should be higher in the CH tasks condition than in the CU condition. CH tasks, such as creating a story for fun, are motivated by the pursuit of enjoyment and originality (Benbya et al., 2024), making creativity the end goal itself. CU tasks, like brainstorming for a report, also require creativity, but it is a means to a functional goal that remains bound by the utilitarian motivation. Finally, when examining the effect of creativity within routine tasks, we propose its impact will be greater in the RH condition than in the RU condition. In RH tasks like finding a movie, a creative result might enhance the anticipation of the enjoyable experience (Casaló et al., 2021), contributing to emotional fit. In RU tasks focused on acquiring factual information, however, creativity is counterproductive and is expected to have the weakest positive influence (Boussiou et al., 2024). This logic provides a rationale for the hypothesized order of creativity's impact. We therefore propose:

H4. a-b: For different tasks, the impact of information creativity on cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b) follows a descending order: creative-hedonic task > creative-utilitarian task > routine-hedonic task > routine-utilitarian task.

3.4. Fit and satisfaction

According to the satisfaction attainment theory, satisfaction is an emotional response associated with the achievement of goals (Briggs et al., 2006). Cognitive fit and emotional fit, within the context of human-GAI interaction, represent distinct yet complementary pathways to desired goal achievement (Chen & Zhou, 2025). Cognitive fit signifies the effective attainment of task-related cognitive goals, while emotional fit reflects the fulfillment of desired affective states (Shiau & Huang, 2023).

According to task-technology fit theory, user satisfaction is maximized when the capabilities of the technology effectively match the demands of the task (Goodhue & Thompson, 1995). Cognitive fit, embodying this alignment, directly enhances users' ability to achieve

their task goals (Garaus et al., 2015). When users perceive a high degree of cognitive fit, they experience a more productive task completion process, leading to superior task outcomes (Vessey, 1991). In the context of GAI, this translates to users feeling more satisfied with the content generated by the GAI because cognitive fit ensures the GAI output is directly relevant and usable for their purpose. Beyond SO, cognitive fit also positively influences SP of using GAI. Cognitive fit, by definition, reduces the cognitive effort required to process AI-generated information for the task (Giboney et al., 2015). When the AI content is represented in a way that aligns well with users' cognitive models and task demands, users experience lower cognitive load during the interaction. According to cognitive load theory, this ease of processing and reduced cognitive effort contribute to a more enjoyable and less frustrating user experience (Cheng et al., 2020). For example, in the scenario of summarizing research papers with ChatGPT, high cognitive fit not only leads to SO but also makes the process of prompting and interacting with ChatGPT feel smooth, thus enhancing SP itself. Therefore, we propose:

H5. a-b. Cognitive fit is positively associated with SO (a) and SP (b).

Emotional fit, representing a desirable affective state during GAI interaction, can positively bias users' evaluation of the outcome (i.e., AI-generated content) (Chen & Zhou, 2025). According to the affective information processing literature (Lutz et al., 2024), when users experience emotional fit, they are more likely to perceive the GAI interaction and its outputs in a favorable light. For example, when using GAI services for emotional support, high emotional fit (feeling understood, supported, and emotionally connected with the chatbot) can enhance users' satisfaction with the specific advice received from the GAI (Y. Xie et al., 2024; Z. Xie et al., 2024), because the positive emotional experience makes the outcome seem more helpful. Furthermore, for many technology uses, particularly those involving interactive systems like GAI, users derive satisfaction directly from the experience itself, beyond purely functional outcomes (Gao et al., 2024). When users experience emotional fit, the entire journey of interacting with the GAI—from initiating prompts to receiving responses—becomes more satisfying (Shiau & Huang, 2023). For example, when using GAI for creative expression like generating AI art, high emotional fit (feeling inspired, amused, and emotionally engaged during the image generation process) directly translates to SP of creating art with AI, regardless of the ultimate artistic quality of the generated image (outcome). Thus, we propose:

H6. a-b. Emotional fit is positively associated with SO (a) and SP (b).

Having established the positive influence of both cognitive fit and emotional fit on SO and SP, we now turn to the relative strength of these relationships. While both fit dimensions contribute to overall satisfaction, the distinct nature of the satisfaction components—SO focusing on the result and SP on the interaction journey—suggests that cognitive and emotional fit may exert differential impacts (Briggs et al., 2006). Drawing upon the process/outcome dimension of the affective response model (Zhang, 2013), we distinguish between SO as an outcome-based affect and SP as a process-based affect. We posit that the relative influence of cognitive fit and emotional fit depends on the conceptual alignment between the object of the fit evaluation and the object of the satisfaction evaluation.

SO is primarily an evaluation of the GAI's output and its utility in achieving the task goal. Theories like task-technology fit posit that user performance and positive evaluations of outcomes are driven by the match between technology features (here, the GAI's output) and task requirements (Goodhue & Thompson, 1995). Cognitive fit directly captures this alignment for the outcome. Similarly, CFT posits that fit enhances problem-solving effectiveness and performance, which are closely tied to outcome evaluation (Vessey, 1991). Furthermore, the IS success model links aspects of information quality (a cognitive assessment) directly to SO (Petter et al., 2013). While the emotional experience might color outcome perception, the primary determinant of SO should be the cognitive evaluation of the output's effectiveness.

Therefore, we expect cognitive fit to be more influential than emotional fit in driving SO.

H7. a. Cognitive fit has a stronger positive impact on SO than emotional fit.

Conversely, SP concerns the user's affective response to the experience of interacting with the GAI. Its object of evaluation is the process. Emotional fit, which captures the affective alignment during the interaction journey, is also primarily focused on the process. According to affective response model, user experience separate process-based affect from outcome evaluation, suggesting that SP is driven primarily by feelings experienced during the interaction (Zhang, 2013). Therefore, a user's feeling that the interaction was emotionally appropriate is the most direct cause of their overall feeling of SP (Djelassi et al., 2018; Folse et al., 2025). While cognitive fit contributes to process smoothness by reducing cognitive load, the overarching affective contentment with the journey itself is likely more strongly determined by emotional alignment. Thus, we propose:

H7. b. Emotional fit has a stronger positive impact on SP than cognitive fit.

4. Research design and methodology

To test our theoretical model, we first conducted a main study using a scenario-based experiment. The main study focuses on ecological validity, examining our proposed relationships across a variety of realistic task contexts (Chiarello et al., 2024). Following the analysis of our main study, we conducted a supplementary post-hoc analysis. This approach allows for a robust robustness check of our findings. Accordingly, the following sections will first detail the methodology and results of the main study. Subsequently, we will present the post-hoc analysis and its findings.

4.1. Experimental design

The main study was designed to test our hypotheses in a set of ecologically valid scenarios that represent common, real-world GAI use cases. We tested our hypotheses by conducting an online scenario experiment. This approach enabled us to assess the respondents' mental representation by exposing them to scenarios that resembled actual human-GAI interaction contexts (Vance et al., 2015). We chose ChatGPT as the context for our experiment due to its popularity, with nearly 1 billion monthly users, making it the fastest-growing GAI website in the world (Digital Information World, 2023). ChatGPT has garnered significant attention and has the potential to radically transform a wide variety of information-intensive tasks (Benbya et al., 2024). In real-life and work settings, ChatGPT is a great choice for users who want to use GAI to complete the tasks in our experiment scenarios, as ChatGPT has demonstrated its capability in performing these tasks (Chiarello et al., 2024; Dwivedi et al., 2023).

The main study employed a 2×2 between-subjects design, manipulating two core dimensions of task representation: task routineness (routine vs. creative) and task hedonism (hedonic vs. utilitarian). To manipulate task routineness, we distinguished between routine and creative tasks, drawing upon the established conceptualization of task routineness in IS literature (John & Kundisch, 2015; Przegalinska et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2014). **Routine** tasks are characterized by well-defined procedures and predictable outcomes, primarily engaging analytical cognitive processes. In contrast, **creative** tasks are inherently unstructured, open-ended, and demand divergent thinking and the generation of novel content. For task hedonism, we differentiated between hedonic and utilitarian tasks, based on the widely recognized dichotomy in user motivations for technology adoption (Tafesse, 2021; Wang et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2024). **Hedonic** tasks are intrinsically motivated and focused on emotional experience, whereas **utilitarian**

tasks are instrumental, emphasizing task efficacy and practical outcomes.

To enhance the ecological validity of the main study, we selected four distinct and widely recognized task domains to represent our four conditions (see Appendix B). Specifically, we selected **searching for high-score movies** as a **routine-hedonic** task. This task is designed to represent a **routine** task as it involves a structured search process with predefined criteria (high scores) and analytical comparison of movie information. Simultaneously, it embodies a **hedonic** task orientation, as the primary goal is entertainment and enjoyment of leisure time. We selected **searching for laptop performance indicators** as a **routine-utilitarian** task. This scenario represents a **routine** task characterized by structured information retrieval and analytical comparison of factual specifications. Furthermore, it embodies a **utilitarian** task orientation, as the user's goal is instrumental: acquiring information to purchase a laptop specifically for work. The focus is on obtaining valuable information for a utilitarian objective. We selected **writing academic reports** as a **creative-utilitarian** task. This task is designed to represent a creative task as it necessitates synthesizing information, formulating arguments, and structuring a coherent academic report—all requiring a degree of creative construction. Concurrently, it embodies a utilitarian task orientation because the primary goal is functional and instrumental: to produce a useful and informative academic output for a specific academic purpose. We selected **creating short stories** as a **creative-hedonic** task. This task is designed to represent a **creative** task due to its open-ended nature, requiring divergent thinking, imaginative content generation, and original storytelling. Moreover, it is classified as a **hedonic** task because the primary motivation is intrinsic enjoyment and creative self-expression. Users engaging in this task are seeking an enjoyable and emotionally fulfilling creative experience.

4.2. Procedure

The procedure for the main study followed five steps, as depicted in Fig. 3. Initially, participants were briefed on the experimental process and provided consent. They were then randomly assigned to one of four task scenarios (see Appendix B) and completed the manipulation check items for that task. Subsequently, participants were presented with a screenshot of a realistic ChatGPT 3.5 interaction tailored to their assigned task. They were instructed to imagine themselves in this scenario to perform the task. Finally, participants completed a post-experimental questionnaire measuring the study's core constructs and their demographic information.

4.3. Measures

All constructs within the research model were measured utilizing scales established in prior studies, with minor adjustments made to fit the research context (see Appendix C). All constructs were measured using reflective measurement. Specifically, information credibility was measured with items adapted from Li & Mao (2015). Information creativity was measured with items adapted from Casaló et al. (2021). Cognitive fit was measured with items adapted from Garaus et al. (2015). Emotional fit was measured with items adapted from Fan et al. (2023). SO and SP were measured with items adapted from Ivanov & Cyr (2014). All items were rated on a seven-point Likert scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree). In the main study, emotional fit

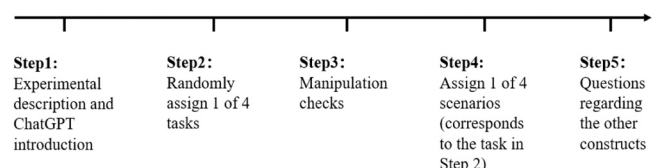


Fig. 3. Scenario experiment procedure.

was operationalized using items reflecting the positive affective valence of the interaction experience (e.g., “nice,” “enjoyed”). While this serves as a proxy for the desired emotional state in our exploratory context, and its validity is supported by supplementary analyses (see [Appendices G and H](#)), we sought to enhance measurement precision in our subsequent post-hoc analysis. Moreover, we conducted supplementary validation analyses, including a two-stage card sorting study and a confirmatory factor analysis, which collectively provide strong support for the content, convergent, and discriminant validity of the scales (see [Appendices G and H](#) for details).

To enhance the robustness of our findings and account for potential confounding factors, we included two control variables: gender and GAI usage frequency. These variables were chosen as they represent demographic and experiential factors that prior literature has shown to influence user satisfaction with technology ([Cheng et al., 2020](#); [Chou, 2020](#)), and controlling for them allows for a more rigorous test of our theoretical model.

4.4. Sample and data collection

Prior to the formal data collection for the main study, we conducted two phases of pretests with 10 IS researchers and 60 respondents. The first pretest involved consultations with 10 IS researchers possessing familiarity with survey methodologies and GAI tools. Key evaluation criteria included: (1) the clarity, fluency, and semantic equivalence of the questionnaire items; (2) the comprehensiveness of the items in capturing the intended constructs within the GAI context; and (3) the appropriateness of our four experimental task scenarios designed to represent the 2×2 framework (routine/creative $\times$ utilitarian/hedonic). Based on the feedback, we implemented several optimizations. Primarily, this involved refining the wording of questionnaire items to enhance clarity. Regarding the experimental materials, the experts generally agreed that the routine-utilitarian, creative-utilitarian, and creative-hedonic task scenarios were appropriate. However, a concern was raised by some experts regarding potential ambiguity in the classification of the “searching for high-score movies” task, questioning whether it would be perceived as fitting the intended “routine-hedonic” category. To rigorously validate the manipulations for all four task types and address the expert feedback, a second, larger pretest was conducted online with 210 respondents (85 male, 125 female) recruited through an MTurk-like platform (wjx.cn) in China. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the four task scenarios. Participants evaluated this task using the manipulation check items for task routineness and task hedonism, as detailed in [Appendix C](#), rated on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). We then performed independent samples t-tests (two-tailed) on this pretest data to check our manipulations. The results showed there was a significant difference in perceived routineness between the routine tasks ($M_{\text{routine}} = 3.34$, $SD = 1.53$) and the creative tasks ($M_{\text{creative}} = 5.65$, $SD = 1.15$); $t(208) = -12.326$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 1.359$. There was a significant difference in perceived hedonism between the hedonic tasks ($M_{\text{hedonic}} = 5.28$, $SD = 1.37$) and the utilitarian tasks ($M_{\text{utilitarian}} = 2.04$, $SD = 0.91$); $t(208) = 19.943$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 1.174$. These statistically significant differences, supported by large effect sizes (Cohen’s $d = 1.359$ and 1.174 , respectively) and means aligning with the intended manipulation directions, confirmed the validity of our experimental manipulations.

Subsequently, we conducted the formal data collection, recruiting a final sample of 548 participants online for the main study. Each participant received approximately 10 Chinese yuan as compensation for their participation. The online scenario experiment was conducted in April 2023 with the assistance of an MTurk-like platform (wjx.cn) in China and lasted for approximately one week. Our sample comprised 242 males (44.16 %) and 306 females (55.84 %). [Appendix D](#) presents the demographic characteristics.

4.5. Manipulation checks

To check our manipulation of the task routineness (routine vs. creative) and task hedonism (utilitarian vs. hedonic) treatment, we asked respondents to rate two sets of statements (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). The manipulation check for task routineness relied on the three items adapted from [John & Kundisch \(2015\)](#) (see [Appendix C](#) for full item wording, e.g., “the task requires divergent thinking”). The manipulation check for task hedonism relied on the three items from [Benoit & Miller \(2019\)](#) (e.g., “the task is to experience pleasure, not to achieve a goal”). A t-test analysis (two-tailed) indicated significant differences in the mean score for “task routineness” between the routine task ($M_{\text{routine}} = 3.42$, $SD = 1.37$) and the creative task ($M_{\text{creative}} = 6.03$, $SD = 0.61$, $t(546) = -28.879$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 1.056$), as well as between the “task hedonism” scores for the hedonic task ($M_{\text{hedonic}} = 5.05$, $SD = 1.31$) and the utilitarian task ($M_{\text{utilitarian}} = 2.43$, $SD = 1.29$, $t(546) = 23.522$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 1.303$). These statistically significant differences, with large effect sizes (Cohen’s $d = 1.056$ and 1.303 ; respectively), and the means being in the expected direction, confirm the validity of our manipulations.

5. Data analysis and results

The main study used SmartPLS 4 for data analysis to test and validate the proposed research model and hypotheses. Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM), a widely recognized variance-based SEM technique, was chosen as the primary method for data analysis in this research ([Evermann & Rönkkö, 2023](#)). PLS-SEM is known for its robustness when dealing with non-normally distributed data and small sample sizes and its ability to address the measured factors and analyze both measurement and structural models ([Hair et al., 2011](#)). Furthermore, PLS is a well-established and widely accepted method for multi-group analysis, which is crucial for our examination of the moderating effects of task routineness and task hedonism. For our hypotheses, we adopt a significance threshold of $p < 0.1$ from the two-tailed test results. Specifically, from a methodological standpoint, this is an acceptable practice in exploratory research, as it corresponds to the standard $p < 0.05$ level for a one-tailed test suitable for directional predictions ([Cohen, 2013](#)). Moreover, this approach finds empirical precedent in prior IS research examining interaction effects or conducting exploratory analyses ([Gao et al., 2022](#); [Han et al., 2022](#); [Wang et al., 2025](#)). To ensure transparency, results at this level are reported as marginally significant.

5.1. Measurement

The measurement model for all constructs was assessed by examining their reliabilities, convergent validities, and discriminant validities. As presented in [Table 2](#), the composite reliability (CR) values for all the constructs exceeded 0.8, and the average variance extracted (AVE) exceeded 0.5, exceeding the recommended threshold values of 0.7 and 0.5, respectively, confirming appropriate reliability for all constructs.

The assessment results (see [Table 3](#)) indicated that the loadings of all items on their respective constructs were above 0.7, and these loadings surpassed cross-loadings. Hence, these constructs demonstrated adequate convergent and discriminant validities. The correlation of each construct with the others was lower than the square root of its own AVE, and each construct differed from the other constructs, indicating satisfactory discriminant validity for these constructs.

5.2. Structural model

To provide a clear overview before delving into the statistical specifics, the key findings of our main study are summarized as follows: information credibility strongly and positively influences both cognitive

Table 2

Descriptive statistics, reliabilities, and correlations.

Construct	Mean	α	SD	AVE	CR	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
(1) CF	5.695	0.659	0.924	0.594	0.814	0.771					
(2) EF	5.812	0.616	1.103	0.721	0.838	0.591	0.849				
(3) ICD	5.614	0.730	1.044	0.552	0.831	0.589	0.534	0.743			
(4) ICT	5.000	0.818	1.378	0.733	0.892	0.370	0.320	0.309	0.856		
(5) SO	5.856	0.756	0.939	0.577	0.845	0.594	0.640	0.572	0.330	0.759	
(6) SP	5.906	0.648	0.894	0.587	0.812	0.579	0.626	0.566	0.301	0.689	0.766

Note. Boldfaced diagonal elements are the square roots of AVE. CF = Cognitive Fit, EF = Emotional Fit, ICD = Information Credibility, ICT = Information Creativity, SO = Satisfaction with Outcome, SP = Satisfaction with Process.

Table 3

Loadings and cross loadings.

Items	CF	EF	ICD	ICT	SO	SP
CF1	0.799	0.508	0.513	0.305	0.486	0.510
CF2	0.725	0.379	0.421	0.278	0.413	0.365
CF3	0.785	0.472	0.421	0.270	0.471	0.452
EF1	0.553	0.875	0.489	0.264	0.588	0.574
EF2	0.447	0.823	0.413	0.282	0.493	0.484
ICD1	0.466	0.453	0.761	0.286	0.454	0.479
ICD2	0.398	0.339	0.726	0.198	0.440	0.374
ICD3	0.445	0.366	0.729	0.192	0.397	0.391
ICD4	0.437	0.416	0.754	0.233	0.410	0.428
ICT1	0.289	0.296	0.212	0.852	0.274	0.253
ICT2	0.346	0.279	0.308	0.872	0.295	0.275
ICT3	0.312	0.247	0.272	0.845	0.277	0.245
SO1	0.494	0.551	0.491	0.310	0.780	0.525
SO2	0.410	0.412	0.420	0.206	0.729	0.537
SO3	0.447	0.480	0.414	0.24	0.745	0.491
SO4	0.447	0.486	0.406	0.234	0.783	0.545
SP1	0.489	0.518	0.472	0.269	0.607	0.806
SP2	0.446	0.448	0.412	0.184	0.451	0.744
SP3	0.392	0.471	0.414	0.236	0.519	0.746

Note. CF = Cognitive Fit, EF = Emotional Fit, ICD = Information Credibility, ICT = Information Creativity, SO = Satisfaction with Outcome, SP = Satisfaction with Process.

fit and emotional fit. Information creativity positively influences emotional fit, though its direct impact on cognitive fit is not statistically significant. Both cognitive fit and emotional fit, in turn, significantly and positively drive SO and SP. The detailed statistical results supporting these key findings are presented below.

Specifically, the PLS results (see Fig. 4) showed that information credibility had positive impacts on cognitive and emotional fit ($\beta = 0.625$, $t = 8.236$, $p < 0.001$; $\beta = 0.578$, $t = 6.851$, $p < 0.001$, respectively; two-tailed test, the same below), lending support to H1a and H1b. Information creativity had a marginally significant impact on emotional fit ($\beta = 0.103$, $t = 1.705$, $p < 0.1$) while its effect on cognitive fit was not significant ($\beta = 0.030$, $t = 0.479$, $p > 0.1$), lending support to H2b but

not H2a. Cognitive fit positively affected SO and SP ($\beta = 0.335$, $t = 6.295$, $p < 0.001$; $\beta = 0.323$, $t = 6.813$, $p < 0.001$), providing support for H5a and H5b. Emotional fit also positively affected SO and SP ($\beta = 0.450$, $t = 8.502$, $p < 0.001$; $\beta = 0.434$, $t = 8.718$, $p < 0.001$), providing support for H6a and H6b. Control variables (gender, usage frequency) predicting SO and SP were included in the PLS-SEM analysis but are omitted from the figure for visual clarity to maintain focus on the hypothesized model. The analysis revealed a significant negative effect of gender (female=1) on SP ($\beta = -0.156$, $t = 2.550$, $p < 0.05$). No other significant effects were found for the paths from the control variables. Information credibility, information creativity, and moderating variables explained collectively 42.0 % and 32.9 % of the variance in cognitive and emotional fit, respectively. Cognitive fit, emotional fit, and control variables (gender and usage frequency) collectively explained 48.2 % and 46.5 % of the variance in SO and SP, respectively.

To test H7a and H7b, which posit differential effects of cognitive fit and emotional fit on SO and SP, we performed statistical comparisons of the relevant path coefficients obtained from the PLS-SEM analysis of the main study data. Specifically, we compared the standardized path coefficient from cognitive fit to SO with that from emotional fit to SO to test H7a. Similarly, we compared the path coefficient from emotional fit to SP with that from cognitive fit to SP to test H7b. Following established procedures for comparing two path coefficients originating from the same model with correlated predictors (Keil et al., 2013; Pavlou & Dimoka, 2006), we calculated a t-statistic for each comparison. Contrary to H7a, we found that emotional fit exerted a stronger influence on SO than cognitive fit ($\beta_{EF \rightarrow SO} = 0.450$ vs. $\beta_{CF \rightarrow SO} = 0.335$; $t = -2.40$, $p < 0.01$). Conversely, H7b was supported, revealing that emotional fit indeed has a significantly stronger impact on SP compared to cognitive fit ($\beta_{EF \rightarrow SP} = 0.434$ vs. $\beta_{CF \rightarrow SP} = 0.323$; $t = 2.53$, $p < 0.01$).

5.3. Multiple-group analysis (MGA)

To test our hypotheses regarding the moderating effects of task routineness and task hedonism (H3 and H4), which predicted descending orders of effect strengths for information credibility and creativity

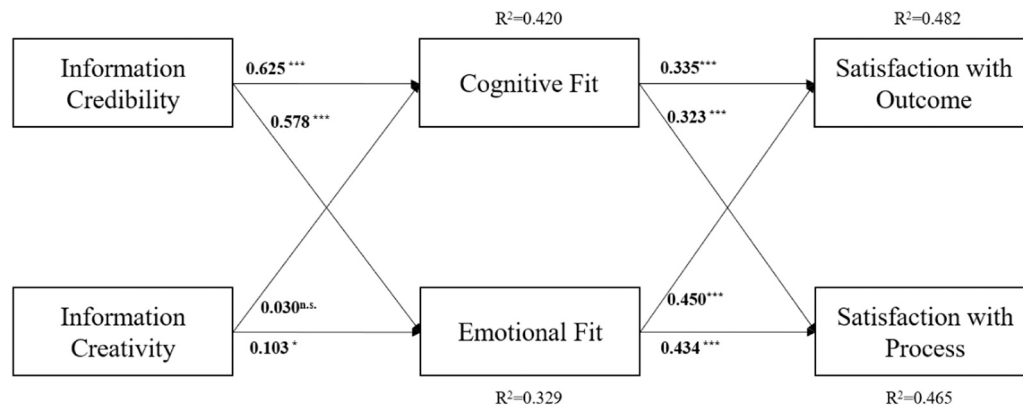


Fig. 4. PLS results (main effects). Note. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.1$, n.s. $p > 0.1$. Numbers on arrows represent path coefficients.

across the four task conditions, we conducted an MGA using SmartPLS 4 on the main study data. MGA allows for the comparison of path coefficients across groups, enabling a test of whether the relationships between information representation and mental representation differ significantly based on task type. Table 4 presents the path coefficients for each group and the results of pairwise significance tests comparing these coefficients. We evaluate H3 and H4 by examining the pattern of coefficients relative to the hypothesized order and assessing the significance of key pairwise differences. Overall, the results from the main study indicate that task routineness and task hedonism act as significant moderators, shaping the influence of information representation dimensions on user fit. Task routineness appears to be a primary moderator, while task hedonism plays a secondary but still discernible role. The impact of information credibility is generally stronger for routine tasks, while information creativity has a greater influence in creative tasks. The hypothesized descending order of effect strengths across different task types is largely supported by the data, with minor inconsistencies for specific task pairings. Specifically, the impact of information credibility on cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b) follows a descending order: routine-hedonic task, routine-utilitarian task, creative-utilitarian task, and creative-hedonic task, while the impact of information creativity on cognitive fit (a) and emotional fit (b) follows a descending order: creative-hedonic task, creative-utilitarian task, routine-utilitarian task, and routine-hedonic task. Additionally, Table 4 presents the pairwise MGA results between the four task types in hypotheses H3a-b and H4a-b, as well as the order of effect strengths of the four task types along a certain path. The results indicate that, except for the inconsistency in the order of routine-utilitarian task and routine-hedonic task, the comparison results among the other five pairs are consistent with the hypothesis. We will discuss these findings in detail in the subsequent section.

6. Post-hoc analysis

While the main study was designed to maximize external validity by demonstrating the model's applicability across four distinct task contexts, this approach involves a trade-off with internal validity. To replicate the findings of the main study in a highly controlled experimental setting to ensure internal validity and to use a refined measure of emotional fit, we conducted a post-hoc analysis.

The post-hoc analysis adopted a 2 × 2 between-subjects design and followed an identical procedure to the main study. To achieve a high degree of experimental control, all four conditions were situated within a unified task domain: seeking pre-purchase information for a new laptop. This design allowed for the precise manipulation of task routineness and task hedonism while holding the overarching task context constant. For example, within the routine task condition, we manipulated task hedonism by framing the goal as either utilitarian (purchasing for work) or hedonic (purchasing for entertainment). Similarly, within the creative task condition, we manipulated task hedonism by framing the goal of brainstorming a laptop design as either utilitarian (for a professional need) or hedonic (for a passionate hobby). To validate these new experimental materials, we first conducted a pre-test with 198 participants, the results of which confirmed that our manipulations were

effective (full details are provided in Appendix I).

Following the pre-test, the formal data collection with a final sample of 197 participants was conducted. The results of this post-hoc analysis strongly corroborated the findings of our main study. Table 5 provides a comprehensive summary of these findings, highlighting the consistency of the results despite the distinct experimental materials. Specifically, the structural model analysis replicated the significant paths identified previously, and the multi-group analysis confirmed the moderating roles of task routineness and task hedonism, with task routineness again emerging as the more dominant moderator. These results provide a robust, internally valid foundation for our model, complementing the ecologically valid evidence from the main study. A detailed description of the methodology, measures, and full results of the post-hoc analysis is presented in Appendix I.

7. Discussion

7.1. Key findings

With the development of GAI in various fields, understanding the factors that contribute to user satisfaction with GAI-generated information is of paramount importance (Cillo & Rubera, 2024; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Larson et al., 2024). This research explores the underlying mechanisms and boundary conditions of users' satisfaction with GAI through a main study focused on ecological validity and a subsequent post-hoc analysis designed for robustness and cross-validation. By triangulating the findings from an ecologically valid main study and an internally valid post-hoc analysis, we can draw several key conclusions, which demonstrate notable consistency across different experimental approaches.

First, regarding the underlying mechanisms, our findings provide

Table 5

Summary of hypothesis tests across main study and post-hoc analysis.

Hypothesis	Supported? (main study)	Supported? (post-hoc analysis)	Consistency of findings
H1a: ICD → CF	Yes	Yes	Yes
H1b: ICD → EF	Yes	Yes	Yes
H2a: ICT → CF	No	No	Yes
H2b: ICT → EF	Yes	Yes	Yes
H3a/b: Moderation (ICD)	Yes (Partially)	Yes (Partially)	Yes
H4a/b: Moderation (ICT)	Yes (Partially)	Yes (Partially)	Yes
H5a: CF → SO	Yes	Yes	Yes
H5b: CF → SP	Yes	Yes	Yes
H6a: EF → SO	Yes	Yes	Yes
H6b: EF → SP	Yes	Yes	Yes
H7a: CF > EF on SO	No (Reversed)	No (Reversed)	Yes
H7b: EF > CF on SP	Yes	Yes	Yes

Note. CF = Cognitive Fit, EF = Emotional Fit, ICD = Information Credibility, ICT = Information Creativity, SO = Satisfaction with Outcome, SP = Satisfaction with Process.

Table 4
MGA results.

Path	RU (n = 138)	RH (n = 135)	CU (n = 144)	CH (n = 131)	RU vs. RH	RU vs. CU	RU vs. CH	RH vs. CU	RH vs. CH	CU vs. CH
ICD→CF	0.619***	0.623***	0.428***	0.322***	−0.004 ^{n.s.}	0.191*	0.297**	0.195*	0.301**	0.106 ^{n.s.}
ICD→EF	0.514***	0.562***	0.493***	0.339***	−0.048 ^{n.s.}	0.021 ^{n.s.}	0.175 ^{n.s.}	0.069 ^{n.s.}	0.223*	0.154*
ICT→CF	0.194**	−0.032 ^{n.s.}	0.337***	0.401***	0.226*	−0.143 ^{n.s.}	−0.207*	−0.369***	−0.433***	−0.064 ^{n.s.}
ICT→EF	0.125*	0.053 ^{n.s.}	0.208**	0.323***	0.072 ^{n.s.}	−0.083 ^{n.s.}	−0.198*	−0.155 ^{n.s.}	−0.27*	−0.115 ^{n.s.}

Note. ***p < 0.001, **p < 0.01, *p < 0.1, ^{n.s.}p > 0.1. ICD = Information Credibility, ICT = Information Creativity, CF = Cognitive Fit, EF = Emotional Fit. RU = Routine-Utilitarian task, RH = Routine-Hedonic task, CU = Creative-Utilitarian task, CH = Creative-Hedonic task. The numbers in the table represent path coefficients. H3 (ICD → CF/EF: RU > RH > CU > CH); H4 (ICT → CF/EF: CH > CU > RH > RU).

replicated evidence for the significant roles of information credibility and creativity. Across both studies, these two dimensions of information representation have a significant influence on cognitive and emotional fit (except for the effect of information creativity on cognitive fit, H2a), which in turn positively impact SO and SP. This pattern of results, robust across both the main study and post-hoc analysis, strongly supports the proposed dual fit theory. Our findings align with the core principles of CFT, which posits that user satisfaction and performance are enhanced when the information representations align well with the demands of the task (Giboney et al., 2015; Huang et al., 2013). Although H2a was not supported in the overall model analysis of either study, our MGA results from both experiments reveal that this relationship is, in fact, highly conditional on the task context. Specifically, the effect becomes significant only in creative tasks (both utilitarian and hedonic) and, as shown in the main study, the routine-utilitarian task, but it is non-existent in the routine-hedonic task. We tentatively attribute this latter finding to the more superficial information processing associated with such tasks. In these scenarios, users are seeking efficient suggestions for enjoyment, and their cognitive processes are not primed to evaluate novel information. Creative content may even be perceived as noise that increases cognitive load rather than enhancing cognitive fit for a routine goal (Büttner et al., 2013). Notably, a key finding that was clearly replicated across both studies is that emotional fit indeed has a significantly stronger impact on SP compared to cognitive fit. This finding aligns with our theorizing and validates the distinction between the two satisfaction dimensions and the two fit constructs. The consistency of this result across the two studies strengthens our conclusion about the critical role of the affective journey in shaping users' experience with GAI and provides strong empirical support for our dual fit framework (Shiau & Huang, 2023). However, in another instance of consistent findings, both studies revealed an unexpected result contrary to H7a: we found that emotional fit exerted a stronger influence on SO. This unexpected finding suggests that SO is not solely determined by its cognitive alignment with task demands. The emotional experience during the interaction appears to significantly spill over, strongly influencing the evaluation of the outcome. This could imply that in the context of highly interactive technologies like GAI (Chen et al., 2025), the boundaries between process experience and outcome evaluation become blurred, with affect playing a surprisingly dominant role even in outcome assessment (Folse et al., 2025). This highlights a potential limitation of viewing outcome satisfaction through a purely cognitive-rational lens in such contexts and underscores the pervasive influence of emotional fit (e.g., Shiau & Huang, 2023).

Second, regarding the boundary conditions, the MGA results from both our main study and post-hoc analysis show that users may respond differently when GAI performs different tasks. Overall, the moderating effect of task routineness is stronger than that of task hedonism. As demonstrated consistently across both experiments, cognitive and emotional fit are enhanced when information credibility aligns with routine tasks and information creativity aligns with creative tasks. Furthermore, credibility tends to better suit utilitarian task needs, while creativity tends to align more with hedonic task orientations. Appendix E provides an expanded discussion and in-depth interpretation of these multi-group comparisons from the main study, the patterns of which were largely replicated in the confirmatory experiment. This signifies that the degree of task routineness (routine vs. creative) is a more decisive contextual factor than task hedonism (hedonic vs. utilitarian) when considering how information credibility and creativity influence user cognitive and emotional fit. The greater moderating effect of task routineness stems from its fundamental influence on the cognitive processing demands of the task, as emphasized by CFT (Dang et al., 2012). CFT posits that optimal performance with IT artifacts arises from the congruence between information representation and task representation, with cognitive resources being a key constraint (Huang et al., 2013). Task routineness directly dictates the predictability and analyzability of a task, thereby shaping the cognitive strategies users adopt

(Przegalinska et al., 2025). This inherent task characteristic, routine-ness, creates a more profound and structural shift in the cognitive landscape of task engagement than hedonism, leading to more substantial variations in how information representation dimensions impact user fit. Here, we use some examples from our main study to illustrate why routineness plays a stronger moderating role than hedonism in the relationship between information credibility and cognitive fit (H1a). The explanation of this pathway can be strategically extended to the other hypotheses. In a routine-utilitarian task like searching for factual information to include in a report, the effect of information credibility on cognitive fit is significantly larger because credibility directly addresses the core cognitive demand for factual accuracy in such tasks. In contrast, in a creative-utilitarian task like brainstorming novel ideas for the same report, this positive impact becomes weaker in comparison because credibility is no longer the primary driver of cognitive fit. The difference in this effect when moving from routine-utilitarian to creative-utilitarian tasks (changing routineness, holding hedonism constant as utilitarian) clearly demonstrates the strong moderating effect of task routineness. In contrast, regarding the moderating effect of task hedonism, again, in the routine-utilitarian task of factual information search, information credibility strongly drives cognitive fit. In a routine-hedonic task, however, this positive impact is only slightly stronger than in the routine-utilitarian task. While users now seek enjoyment (hedonic motivation), they still rely on credible ratings and reviews to guide their movie selection and ensure a positive experience. The difference in this effect when moving from routine-utilitarian to routine-hedonic tasks (changing hedonism, holding routineness constant as routine) is much smaller compared to the change seen when altering task routineness. This general pattern, highlighting the dominance of task routineness as a moderator, was also supported by the results of the post-hoc analysis and further examined by our supplementary mediation and moderated mediation analyses. To further investigate the downstream consequences of these moderating effects, we conducted supplementary mediation and moderated mediation analyses on the main study data (see Appendix F), the results of which corroborate the PLS and MGA findings, particularly regarding the stronger moderating influence of task routineness compared to task hedonism on the overall indirect effects leading to user satisfaction.

Furthermore, consistent with our hypotheses (H3a, H3b, H4a, H4b), our main study and post-hoc analysis found that the effects of information credibility and information creativity on cognitive and emotional fit do indeed vary significantly across different task types. Specifically, the effect of information creativity on cognitive and emotional fit is stronger when performing creative tasks than when performing routine tasks, while the effect of information credibility on cognitive and emotional fit is stronger when performing routine tasks than when performing creative tasks. This aligns with prior research in IS fields that has emphasized the importance of task-technology fit in determining the effectiveness of IT (Jeyaraj, 2022; Rai & Selnes, 2019). This overall pattern also supports the core proposition of CFT—that fit is task-dependent and context-specific (Bačić & Henry, 2022; Giboney et al., 2015; Hong et al., 2004). However, in the main study, there were no significant differences observed in the impact of information credibility on cognitive and emotional fit, as well as in the impact of information creativity on emotional fit, across routine-hedonic tasks and routine-utilitarian tasks. One possible explanation is that the boundary between routine-utilitarian and routine-hedonic tasks in the context of GAI may be relatively ambiguous (Chiarello et al., 2024). For instance, movie recommendation could be regarded as a hedonic task, while still providing users with high-quality recommendations that carries functional value. Similarly, information retrieval in individual learning is typically seen as a utilitarian task, yet users may also get enjoyable interactions and experiences with hedonic aspects (Y. Xie et al., 2024; Z. Xie et al., 2024). Additionally, we also observed another unexpected result: within routine-hedonic tasks, the impact of information creativity on cognitive and emotional fit is not significant. We tentatively attribute

this to the potentially lower cognitive engagement typically associated with routine-hedonic tasks. In these tasks, such as browsing movie recommendations for leisure, users may engage in more superficial or less cognitively demanding information processing. In such scenarios, variations in information creativity might be less likely to significantly influence users' cognitive evaluations or emotional responses compared to contexts with higher cognitive load or more goal-directed information seeking. This interpretation is consistent with research on information processing depth, which suggests that user responses to information cues (like creativity) can be attenuated under conditions of low cognitive elaboration (Büttner et al., 2013; Lutz et al., 2024).

7.2. Implications for research

This study makes three primary contributions to the literature. Firstly, it contributes to GAI user satisfaction research by identifying two core dimensions of the information representation of AI-generated content (i.e., information credibility and creativity) as key antecedents of user satisfaction. It further explores cognitive and emotional fit as potential mechanisms underlying satisfaction formation. Previous studies have primarily focused on the credibility of AI-generated content, neglecting to concurrently investigate its creativity, which is an essential characteristic of such content (Kim et al., 2023; J.S. Kim et al., 2024; T. Kim et al., 2024; Zhao et al., 2025). By extending the CFT theory to dual fit theory that considers emotional fit and drawing on recent studies on information value (Setyani et al., 2019), we advance the understanding of GAI user satisfaction by considering fit as a process by which users evaluate the information value of AI-generated content. Traditional CFT, while robust in structured decision-making contexts (Chen et al., 2021; Garaus et al., 2015), offers an incomplete picture of user experience in human-GAI interaction because it primarily focuses on the alignment of cognitive processing and information representation, overlooking the inherently affective dimensions of this interaction. Our proposed dual fit theory, tested and supported across both of our studies, enriches CFT's explanatory power and provides a more holistic account of user satisfaction, particularly in interactions characterized by both process and outcome orientation (Shiau & Huang, 2023). Mirroring the HCAI imperative to understand the complete human experience, this study also contributes to the satisfaction literature by distinguishing between SO and SP within the GAI context. Our research responds to calls for more contextual conceptualizations of user satisfaction in IT contexts (Zhang, 2013), and provides empirical validation for the importance of this distinction in the GAI context across both ecologically-valid and internally-valid settings. By addressing the gap in prior GAI satisfaction studies that viewed satisfaction as an overall construct (e.g., Jo, 2024; Niu, 2024), this study provides operationalization references for future GAI research. This aligns with the goals of human-centered AI that requires a deep understanding of multifaceted user responses (Capel & Brereton, 2023; Shneiderman, 2020), including both the journey and the destination of technology interaction.

Second, this study contributes to CFT by extending the information representation of this theory to information value in the GAI context. We theoretically refine CFT's concept of information representation by shifting its focus from information format to information value in the GAI context. While prior CFT research has predominantly examined the fit between various information formats (e.g., list vs. matrix, table vs. graph, textual vs. visual information) and task (Chen, 2017; Hong et al., 2004; Speier, 2006), this study innovatively reconceptualizes information representation within CFT to encompass users' perceived information value of AI-generated content, specifically credibility and creativity. This theoretical shift is crucial in the GAI context because, unlike traditional IT artifacts with pre-defined formats, the inherent value proposition of GAI lies in generating novel and valuable information content (Lee & Chung, 2024). Therefore, we offer a more theoretically relevant and practically meaningful operationalization of this core CFT construct for understanding user interactions with GAI

services. Furthermore, this study significantly enhances CFT's understanding of mental representation by proposing the dual fit theory, which incorporates emotional fit alongside cognitive fit (Wendel & Dellaert, 2009). Existing IS literature applying CFT has predominantly focused on cognitive fit as the sole mental representation (Chen et al., 2021), overlooking the affective dimensions of user-GAI interaction. By introducing emotional fit as a complementary and equally important form of mental representation, this study addresses calls within the IS field for research to delve deeper into the affective aspects of CFT (Chen, 2017; Shiau & Huang, 2023). Moreover, John & Kundisch (2015) called for a more comprehensive perspective to explain the mechanisms and boundary conditions of cognitive fit, as previous cognitive fit research has addressed only one of the two types of task routineness that exist: routine tasks. Our study answers this call by examining the moderating effect of both types of task routineness.

Third, this study contributes to the literature on GAI and service segmentation by examining the boundary conditions of information representation on cognitive and emotional fit. Previous research primarily explored the impact of task routineness on employee attitudes and behaviors within organizational settings (Chung & Jackson, 2013; Wang et al., 2014) and the moderating effect of task hedonism in frontline service encounters (Wang et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2024), without considering the characteristics of tasks performed by GAI. We extend this focus to scenarios where users engage with GAI services to complete tasks of different task routineness and hedonism. Our consistent findings from two experiments reveal significant differences in the impact of information creativity and credibility on cognitive and emotional fit when GAI performs different tasks.

7.3. Implications for practice

The findings from our main study and post-hoc analysis enable GAI service providers and developers to tailor their efforts further through several potential interventions to improve user satisfaction. First, practitioners should consider the information value of AI-generated content as two key antecedents of cognitive and emotional fit and recognize their role in enhancing user satisfaction. Importantly, practitioners can survey user satisfaction from both process and outcome dimensions rather than just by asking users if they are satisfied with their GAI services. In this way, practitioners can gain clearer insights into the sources of user contentment or frustration. For example, low SP scores, even when SO scores are acceptable, clearly signal issues within the interaction experience itself, suggesting a need to focus development resources on improving the user interface (e.g., improving navigational clarity), the conversational flow (e.g., offering predictive query suggestions), or the system responsiveness (e.g., providing feedback during processing). Conversely, high SP coupled with low SO indicates that the core problem lies with the quality of the generated output, pointing towards a need for improvements in the underlying AI model or its training data. This targeted approach allows for more efficient allocation of development resources compared to relying on an overall satisfaction metric. Recognizing the duality of GAI satisfaction encourages a more holistic design approach, balancing algorithmic performance (outcome) with user-centered interaction design (process).

Secondly, our results suggest that a good match between information and task representation leads to cognitive and emotional fit. In addition to emphasizing the importance of information creativity and credibility, it is significant for practitioners to ensure a match between routine tasks and more credible information as well as between creative tasks and more creative information. Developers can allow the GAI to identify whether the task type is more routine or creative and thus adjust the GAI parameters automatically. For instance, "Temperature" is a parameter that controls the diversity of the generated results in the GPT-4 framework. A heightened temperature setting could be more suitable for creative tasks, whereas a lower setting could be better for routine tasks. To enhance cognitive fit in routine tasks like factual queries, developers

can design interfaces that present information in concise lists or tables, with clear source citations, ensuring efficient information retrieval and processing. For creative tasks, interfaces can be designed to support divergent thinking, offering varied formats like mind maps or analogies to present AI-generated creative suggestions, thereby enhancing involvement. Furthermore, to enhance emotional fit, AI developers should consider tailoring the tone and language style of GAI responses to match task context and user emotional needs. For example, for sensitive tasks like providing medical symptom information, a cautious, empathetic, and professionally toned response would enhance emotional fit by fostering trust and reducing anxiety. In contrast, for hedonic tasks like generating creative writing or brainstorming, a more playful and encouraging tone can enhance the user's emotional connection with the GAI services, thus boosting emotional fit and overall satisfaction.

7.4. Limitations and future research

Although our findings are valuable, some methodological and practical limitations need to be considered. First, our sample for both studies consisted solely of participants from China. Cultural factors may play a significant role in shaping user perceptions of technology, including GAI services. For instance, cultural values prevalent in China, such as collectivism or technology optimism, might influence how Chinese users perceive the credibility and creativity of AI-generated content, potentially differing from users in other cultural contexts. Therefore, caution should be exercised when generalizing our findings to other cultural contexts. Future research should explicitly investigate the role of cultural factors and conduct cross-cultural comparisons to examine the generalizability of our model and findings across diverse cultural backgrounds.

Second, we exclusively selected one GAI service (i.e., ChatGPT) as the focus of our research. While ChatGPT is indeed a highly representative GAI service, boasting nearly 1 billion monthly users and demonstrating capabilities across various tasks, this singular focus inevitably limits the generalizability of our findings to other GAI platforms. Different GAI services may possess varying algorithms, interfaces, output styles, and task-specific capabilities, which could potentially influence user perceptions and satisfaction. To address this limitation and enhance the external validity of future research, we encourage subsequent studies to explore our research model using diverse types of GAI services. This includes investigating other text-based GAI platforms (e.g., Gemini, Claude, and DeepSeek) as well as GAI services specializing in other modalities, such as music, image, and video generation. Furthermore, while this study focused on task routineness and task hedonism as key moderators, we acknowledge that other potential boundary conditions may exist (e.g., individual traits and other task characteristics). Future research could explicitly explore these potential boundary conditions to further refine our understanding of user satisfaction in the context of GAI.

Third, the rapid advancements in the field of GAI present an inherent challenge to the temporal generalizability of our findings. While our study captures user perceptions at a specific point in time, the field of AI is characterized by exceptionally rapid advancements (e.g., the release of more powerful reasoning models like DeepSeek R1 and OpenAI o3), which may impact user perceptions and satisfaction with GAI services. Reasoning models, unlike earlier general-purpose models (e.g., ChatGPT 3.5 in our main study), are specifically engineered to excel in complex tasks requiring multi-step logical inference and problem-solving. In addition to getting high-quality results, users can also clearly see the thought process of model reasoning to generate responses. These advancements may have implications for our findings, particularly concerning user perceptions of credibility and creativity. Furthermore, the increasing availability and user awareness of these powerful models may also raise user expectations for GAI performance overall, potentially influencing satisfaction benchmarks. Future research should proactively investigate the evolving impact of these advancements on user

perceptions and satisfaction.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Qinwei Li: Methodology, Investigation, Data curation. **Yongqiang Sun:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Project administration, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Bo Yang:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A. Supporting information

Supplementary data associated with this article can be found in the online version at [doi:10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2025.102980](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2025.102980).

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